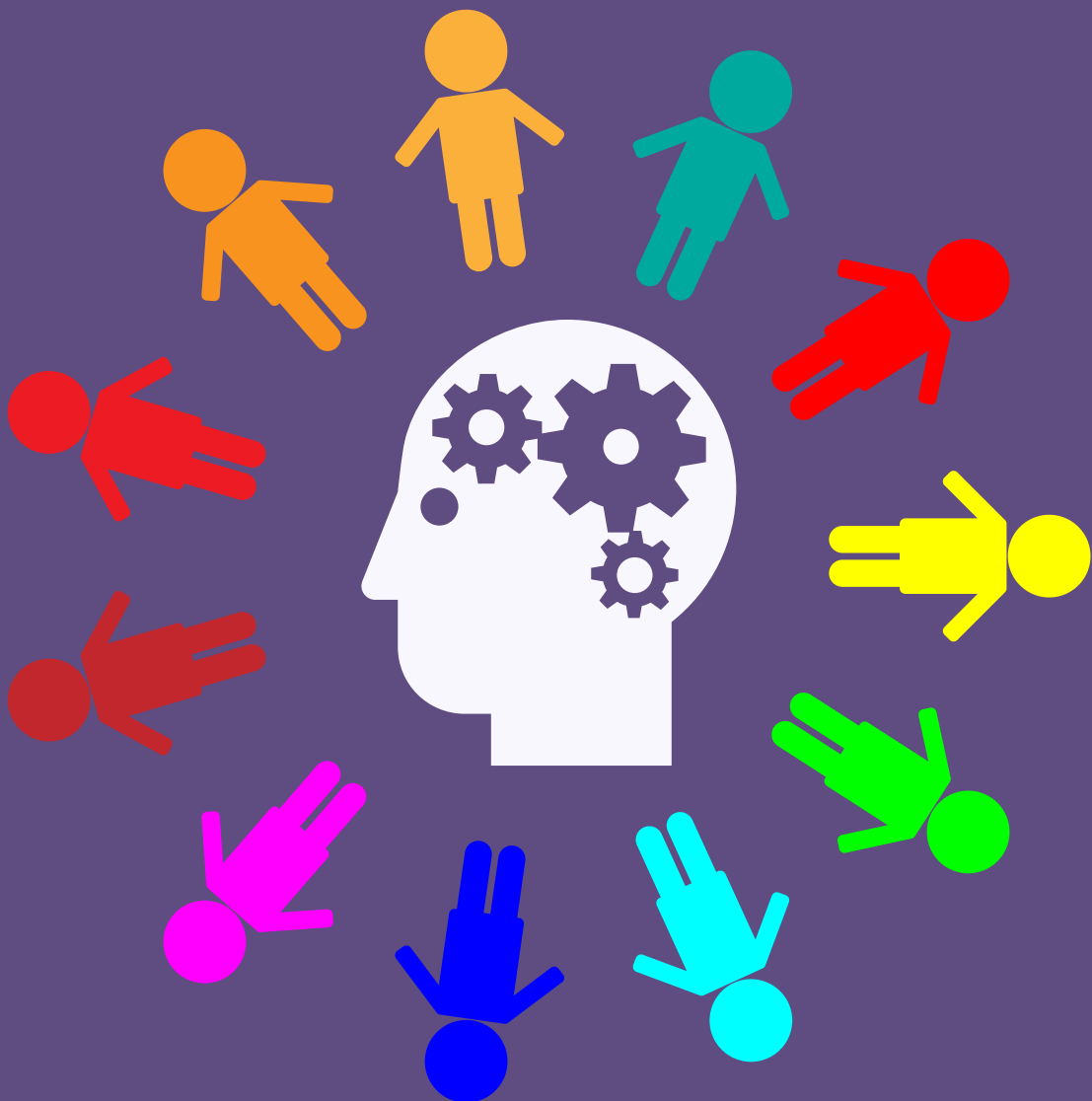




WEBINAR REPORT

GENDER NEUTRAL APPROACH TO MENTAL HEALTH





INTRODUCTION

The webinar on “A Gender Neutral Approach to Mental Health” sought to reframe how mental health is understood, discussed, and addressed across diverse populations. Traditionally, mental health narratives have been shaped by gendered expectations, often reinforcing stereotypes around emotional expression, resilience, and help-seeking behavior. These frameworks, while deeply embedded in social and cultural contexts, have contributed to unequal recognition of mental health needs and barriers to accessing care.

This session aimed to move beyond binary and restrictive perspectives, recognizing that mental health is fundamentally a human experience influenced by a range of factors including biology, environment, relationships, and lived realities. By adopting a gender-neutral approach, the discussion emphasized the importance of inclusivity ensuring that individuals are not limited or defined by societal expectations tied to gender.

The webinar brought together insights on how language, social conditioning, and systemic structures shape mental health outcomes, often marginalizing certain groups while overlooking others. It highlighted the need for more responsive and people-centric frameworks that allow individuals to express vulnerability, seek support, and access care without stigma or exclusion.

Overall, the session set the stage for a critical examination of existing mental health approaches and encouraged a shift towards more equitable, inclusive, and human-centered practices.



CONTEXT SETTING

The webinar opened with a context-setting address by Ms. Pinaki Gakhar, Founder of Our Gender Lens, who welcomed participants to the session titled “A Gender Neutral Approach to Mental Health.” She began by encouraging the audience to reflect on why a gender-neutral perspective in mental health is necessary, noting that most existing conversations have been shaped by deeply embedded gender norms.

Ms. Gakhar explained that societal expectations often dictate how individuals experience and express emotions. While some are conditioned to suppress their feelings and “stay strong,” others are expected to be inherently expressive and nurturing. These expectations, though often perceived as positive traits, come with unintended consequences. They can lead to the dismissal of certain individuals’ struggles as excessive, while preventing others from acknowledging or articulating their own emotional experiences. She also highlighted that individuals who do not fit into traditional gender categories are frequently excluded from these conversations, leaving critical gaps in understanding and support.

She clarified that a gender-neutral approach does not mean ignoring gender, but rather ensuring that it does not become a limiting factor. It involves creating safe and inclusive spaces where individuals can express vulnerability without fear of judgment or labeling.

Emphasizing that mental health is fundamentally human, she noted that it is shaped by a combination of biological, environmental, and lived experiences, rather than gender alone.



CONTEXT SETTING

Ms. Gakhar further pointed out that viewing mental health through a gendered lens can result in significant oversights. For instance, men may underreport distress due to stigma, women's symptoms may be normalized or overlooked, and entire communities may lack access to systems that reflect their realities.

She concluded by urging participants to reflect on how gender norms have shaped their own perceptions of mental health and to consider what might change if mental health were approached simply through a human lens.



SESSION BY DR. SHILPA SURI

The session by Dr. Shilpa Suri focused on unpacking the concept of gender neutrality through a mental health lens. She began by clarifying that gender exists on a continuum, often understood as fluidity, and highlighted that this has historically not been acknowledged. As a result, mental health frameworks have largely remained confined to binary understandings of gender.

She emphasized the need to “address the human in us,” noting that mental health struggles are universal and cut across all identities. According to her, mental health is the ability to feel alive and functional, to remain in charge of one’s emotions, and to demonstrate psychological resilience. She described it as the capacity to bounce back from challenges and maintain healthy social functioning, adding that these are skills that can be built over time.

Dr. Suri pointed out that language plays a significant role in shaping mental health perspectives. She explained that historically, language has been male-centric and patriarchal, often limiting emotional expression through labeling. This, in turn, affects how individuals seek help and how accessible mental health support becomes. She also noted that current educational curricula do not adequately address gender-neutral approaches to mental health treatment.

Addressing the stigma around help-seeking, she challenged the idea that asking for help is a weakness. Instead, she framed it as an act of courage, drawing a comparison with physical health, where seeking assistance is normalized. She further explained that substance abuse can sometimes stem from the suppression of emotions, particularly among men who are socially conditioned to appear strong and unemotional.



SESSION BY DR. SHILPA SURI

She encouraged participants to develop self-awareness and emotional regulation, stating that understanding who you are, learning inhibition, and processing emotions are essential life skills. Highlighting the importance of emotional literacy, she noted that “naming an emotion helps tame it,” and emphasized the need to sit with and process emotions rather than avoid them.

Towards the end, she addressed gender-specific challenges. She noted that women often face role conflict and “mother guilt” while balancing personal and professional responsibilities, and emphasized the importance of setting boundaries and investing in oneself. For men, she discussed the pressure of being the provider, which can lead to silent burnout. She also highlighted the experiences of non-binary individuals, who often face prejudice and discrimination due to a lack of societal acceptance of gender fluidity. She encouraged them to find supportive communities and remain self-assured, emphasizing that identity is not fixed but evolves over time.

The session concluded with a call to adopt more inclusive, empathetic, and self-aware approaches to mental health, recognizing that every individual, regardless of gender identity, is a complete human being.

Thank You!